Kai Sovereignty

Executive Summary

Kai sovereignty is the freedom and responsibility of Tangata Whenua to protect ancestral food systems and the cultural knowledge, practices and ceremonies connected to the production, distribution and consumption of kai. Māori have the right to access, manage, share and produce safe and nourishing kai for our communities. Our tūpuna practised kai sovereignty for generations. This policy supports the transition from kai dependency to kai sovereignty. It protects whakapapa and mātauranga, rebuilds community and commercial food production, creates Māori-owned retail alternatives, and helps whānau afford kai now through the Income Tax Kai Credit.

Noou te rourou, naaku te roourou, ka ora ai te iwi

Context

Agriculture is one of Aotearoa's most significant primary industries, yet two of its key products; dairy and meat, are almost exclusively export products. Around 95 percent of milk and more than 80 percent of meat are exported overseas.

Leading companies in this industry are causing detrimental harm to our taiao as they continue to intensify production at the expense of land, water and soil. At the same time, many people in Aotearoa cannot afford to put basic kai on the table.

It is unacceptable that Aotearoa exploits the environment to provide food for the world while so many whānau experience food poverty, compounded by rising costs and generations of entrenched poverty.

Our Position

We need sustainable ways to provide more food for everyone in Aotearoa while breaking the stranglehold that monopolies have on food supply; across production, distribution and retail.

Our vision is to facilitate and support the transition of Māori from kai dependency to kai sovereignty: **to feed the community, teach the community to feed themselves, and empower them to feed each other.**

We acknowledge Māori growers, hunters, regenerative agriculture farmers, related business owners, governance leaders, and kaupapa Māori and Indigenous researchers who have kept tūpuna practices alive.

We must return to our traditional practices and customs of gathering kai because our sustenance can no longer be in the hands of corporate-controlled food chains.

Our Vision

- Traditional practices, customs and ceremonies of gathering kai are revitalised.
- Whānau and communities have safe, clean and pure kai.
- Food security is realised and food poverty is eliminated.
- Soil is protected and restored.
- Independent and collaborative Māori-led approaches to kai are established.

Why community capability matters

Normalising the growing and distribution of kai at whānau and community level saves money, promotes healthy lifestyles, and builds unity and purpose. It strengthens our collective tools and knowledge for the benefit of all.

Marae have been at the forefront as first responders, distributing kai through national and civil emergency events such as Covid-19, Cyclone Gabrielle and flooding. They must be supported to continue these essential services.

Te Pāti Māori will...

1. Protect the whakapapa of kai

The kai we consume has whakapapa and sits within ecosystems that we are also part of. Seeds hold whakapapa and must not be tampered with. Decisions about flora, fauna and the wider environment that are symbiotic with Māori culture must be conceived of and determined by Tangata Whenua.

- Honour WAI 262 and reject research and commercialisation of Indigenous plant species undertaken without whānau, hapū and iwi consent.
- Support Māori kai licensing and trademarks to protect the whakapapa of heritage seed and Māori intellectual property rights.
- Develop a Māori Seed Conservation Strategy.
- Oppose the introduction of genetically engineered food.

2. Establish a Māori Kai Sovereignty Board

A national body with statutory powers is needed to advance kai sovereignty and justice, working with whānau, hapū, iwi and Māori organisations and partnering with the sectors and agencies that influence our ability to feed ourselves.

- Establish an independent Māori Kai Sovereignty Board with statutory powers to oversee kai sovereignty and justice.
- Mandate the Board to lead work addressing hunger, poverty and inequality, and to ensure struggling communities are represented in decisions that govern our kai systems.

3. Invest in community kai

Kai sovereignty requires the growing and distribution of kai to become normal at whānau and community level.

- Establish a $100 million Community Kai Fund for home-garden establishment, marae māra kai, and Māori and community-led food farms at scale.
- Work with councils to set aside more land for urban and rural food farms.
- Establish Crown-funded kai sovereignty scholarships for rangatahi to pursue food sciences, marine biology and primary-industry skills.

$100 million for whānau, marae and community food systems.

4. Build Māori production capability

Tangata Whenua must be supported to restore our capacity to feed our own people while growing our economic base. We will reduce dependence on agribusiness and corporate-controlled food chains by strengthening local kai markets and networks.

- Invest an additional $100 million into a Mātai Ahuwhenua agricultural innovation fund to support small-scale and diversified pāmu/whenua blocks that prioritise regenerative and organic farming practices, and local consumption.
- Fund regenerative and organic farming training and technical programmes, including support for agroforestry.
- Support garden-to-market food production that strengthens both food security and regional development.

$100 million to support regenerative Māori agriculture and diversified whenua-based production.

5. Build Māori-owned retail alternatives

The supermarket duopoly has a stranglehold over food retail in Aotearoa. It must be broken so that Māori and other independent grocers can gain a foothold in the market.

- Secure Crown or council-owned land in commercially viable areas
- Invest $100 million in seed funding, so Māori collectives can establish supermarket chains.

Protect the rights of whānau to sell homegrown and homekill kai at the local community level, including roadside kai; without interference or taxation.

$100 million seed funding for the establishment of supermarket chains

6. Deliver a Kai Credit

The long-term transformation of our kai systems must be matched with immediate relief for whānau who are struggling with the cost of kai.

- Provide an Income Tax Kai Credit to people earning $60,000 or less.
- Set the credit at a value equivalent to up to eight weeks of kai each year.
- Deliver support to an estimated 3 million people (64 percent of Aotearoa).
- Fund the Kai Credit at an estimated fiscal cost of $2.8 billion.

Our Commitment

From kai dependency to kai sovereignty.

Te Pāti Māori will ensure communities are fed, communities are taught to feed themselves and empower communities to feed each other.

We will protect whakapapa, seed and mātauranga; strengthen whānau, marae and community food systems; restore Māori production capability; and build Māori ownership in retail and distribution.

The Income Tax Kai Credit will give millions of people immediate support with the cost of kai, while the wider policy rebuilds the land, knowledge, infrastructure and ownership needed for long-term sovereignty.

Our vision is safe, clean and nourishing kai; food security and the elimination of food poverty; restored soil and taiao; and independent, collaborative Māori-led kai systems.

AFFORD THE KAI. GROW THE KAI. OWN THE SYSTEM.